movements such as that being orchestrated by Gandhi or Kuchik Khan, for example. While Roy believed Gandhi was a 'reactionary', and should be denounced by the Comintern, Lenin believed that the Indian leader was a 'revolutionary' deserving of all encouragement Communist organisations could give.[108] By supporting the likes of Gandi, the Bolshevik leader argued, more headway would be made in removing British influence from South Asia which was a fundamental step in securing Soviet Russia and in furthering the general revolutionary cause. In effect, the nationalist and pan-Islamist were to be used for their ability to cause general disruption in the region – Communist revolution could then follow.[109] This was the tactic Lenin chose to advocate in Persia, India and Central Asia where alliances where to be made between the Bolsheviks and Muslim modernist and nationalist groups such as the Jadids.[110]

Ultimately, the Bolshevik leader's opinions held sway over Roy's, and the congress agreed that support should be given to the nationalist movements across Asia. From this meeting arose the 'Directives on the Nationality and the Colonial Question', signed by Lenin and from here on out the guiding document for the Comintern on all its Asian affairs.[111] Finally, it appeared that some order was to be brought to Bolshevik policies towards Central and South Asia. Efforts were to be made to pander to nationalist sentiment and Communists were to tread lightly with Muslim revolutionaries in order not to cause an Islamic backlash against the Bolsheviks. However, while the theory had been worked-out, the practicalities of such policy was another matter, as shall come to be seen.

The debate on Gandhi and the issue of Asian nationalism at the Comintern congress would have been particularly worrying to the Indian government in 1920. A report by the Home Department in February had noted that 'there is no evidence in our possession to show that Bolshevik agents have reached India and started direct propaganda, but certain extremists...have been presenting Bolshevik theories in most favourable light'.[112] As the year was to develop, the growth of nationalist agitation in India threatened to bring Bolshevism into the country despite all of the government's endeavours. In May, old wounds were reopened when the Hunter Commission published its report into the events of April 1919 in India and the actions of General Dyer at Amritsar. While the Hunter report